

Future bright: Malleswari is also doing her bit to prop up the sport, through her academy in Yamunanagar, Haryana, which currently trains 55 young weightlifters. THE HINDU PHOTO LIBRARY

"Among those three who went for the Asian Games, we had high hopes for Mirabai. Unfortunately, she couldn't deliver. There seems to be a shortage of good weightlifters in our country. Hopefully, in the next four or five years, the next generation will take over," she pointed out.

The 48-year-old Malleswari is also doing her bit to prop up the sport, through her academy in Yamunanagar, Haryana, which currently trains 55 young weightlifters.

"It [her academy] is a fully residential facility, where everything from training, diet, education and coaching is free. 35 of those students are supported by the SBI Foundation, while the other 20 are backed by the KM Foundation. I hope in the coming days, a lot more corporates come forward with their CSR backing so that we can develop weightlifting in our country.

I can feel a growing sense of interest in the sport. All the talent in my academy have come from the grassroots level and a lot of them have already won medals at the national and international level. I believe that by 2036, one of my academy products will bring home an Olympic medal," said Malleswari, with pride and a dash of optimism.

Another crisis plaguing Indian weightlifting has been the rise in doping cases. As per the National Anti-Doping Agency's annual report for 2022-23, 22 positive cases were reported in weightlifting in the country, the second-most after athletics.

Malleswari was quick to spell out the perils of doping. "Ultimately, nothing good will come out of doping. However, younger athletes often get misguided and then shift to the path of doping. What they don't realise is the consequences of engaging in doping."

"All I have to say to such athletes

is — don't fall for doping. If you don't work hard with full focus and dedication during your training period, no medicine will ever help you in your performance. Results will only come if you practice wholeheartedly," she added.

The biggest highlight in the world of weightlifting in 2023 was the return of North Korea to the global fold, after a self-imposed break following the COVID-19 pandemic. Its weightlifters dominated the 2023 Asian Games, breaking six world records in the process. It only got better at the 2024 Asian Weightlifting Championship, where the North Koreans entered 11 athletes and won 11 golds.

But North Korean weightlifters will sit out of the Paris Olympics, due to their nation's non-compliance with global doping regulations. Malleswari though has no sympathy for them.

"It is unfair to other athletes if you allow doped players to take part in competitions. If any country brings doped athletes to an event, it is an injustice as they will eventually lose the medal and those who deserve to win the medal will be heartbroken.

But, as a competitor, I strongly believe that it doesn't matter what country or athlete turns up. If your preparation is perfect, nobody can stop you," she added.

